

# 96 Hezekiah

*The king who trusted God when the Assyrian army stood at Jerusalem's walls.*

Hezekiah was the son of Ahaz, one of Judah's worst kings, yet he became one of its best. In his first month as king he reopened the temple his father had shut, cleansed it, and called all Israel to keep the Passover. He smashed idols and even the bronze serpent Moses had made, because people were burning incense to it. When Sennacherib of Assyria invaded and demanded surrender, Hezekiah spread the enemy's letter before the LORD and prayed, and Jerusalem was saved. When he fell ill, he wept and prayed, and God gave him fifteen more years. Pride later led him to show off his treasures to Babylon's envoys. But Scripture says no king of Judah trusted the LORD like him.

## At a glance

|               |                                                             |
|---------------|-------------------------------------------------------------|
| Name          | Hebrew <i>Chizqiyahu</i> , "the LORD strengthens"           |
| Family        | Son of Ahaz and Abi; father of Manasseh (2 Kings 18:2)      |
| Reign         | 29 years from age 25, c. 715–686 BC (some say from c. 729)  |
| Key places    | Jerusalem, the temple, Lachish, the Gihon spring            |
| Key people    | Isaiah, Micah, Sennacherib, the Rabshakeh, Merodach-baladan |
| Main passages | 2 Kings 18–20; 2 Chronicles 29–32; Isaiah 36–39             |
| New Testament | Named as "Ezekias" in Matthew 1:9–10                        |

*"He trusted in the LORD God of Israel; so that after him was none like him among all the kings of Judah, nor any that were before him."*

2 Kings 18:5, KJV

# The life of Hezekiah

Dates are approximate (BC). *2 Kings 18:13* fits an accession c. 715 BC; *2 Kings 18:9–10* leads some to date it c. 729 BC, perhaps as co-regent.

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|----------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>c. 715 BC</b><br>Age 25       | ● <b>Becomes king</b><br>Hezekiah succeeds Ahaz and does right in the sight of the LORD, as David had done. <i>2 Kings 18:1–3; 2 Chronicles 29:1–2</i>                           |
| <b>c. 715 BC</b><br>First month  | ● <b>Reopens the temple</b><br>He repairs the temple doors and has the priests and Levites cleanse the house. Worship is restored. <i>2 Chronicles 29:3–36</i>                   |
| <b>Early in his reign</b>        | ● <b>Passover for all Israel</b><br>He invites everyone from Beersheba to Dan. Many in the north mock, but some come, and there is great joy. <i>2 Chronicles 30:1–27</i>        |
| <b>Early in his reign</b>        | ● <b>Tears down idols</b><br>He removes the high places and destroys the bronze serpent, calling it Nehushtan. <i>2 Kings 18:4; 2 Chronicles 31:1</i>                            |
| <b>c. 701 BC</b><br>14th year    | ● <b>Sennacherib invades</b><br>Assyria takes Judah's fortified cities. Hezekiah pays heavy tribute, but an army still comes to Jerusalem. <i>2 Kings 18:13–17</i>               |
| <b>c. 701 BC</b><br>Under siege  | ● <b>Prayer and deliverance</b><br>The Rabshakeh mocks Judah's God. Hezekiah prays, and the angel of the LORD strikes the Assyrian camp. <i>2 Kings 18:17–19:37</i>              |
| <b>c. 701 BC</b><br>Age about 39 | ● <b>Sick unto death</b><br>Isaiah tells him to set his house in order. Hezekiah weeps and prays, and God adds fifteen years to his life. <i>2 Kings 20:1–11; Isaiah 38:1–22</i> |
| <b>c. 686 BC</b><br>Age 54       | ● <b>Dies</b><br>He is buried with honour, and his son Manasseh reigns in his place. <i>2 Kings 20:21; 2 Chronicles 32:33</i>                                                    |

## Key activities

*Sennacherib's own records say he shut Hezekiah up in Jerusalem "like a bird in a cage," but they do not claim that he took the city. Carvings of his siege of Lachish survive from his palace at Nineveh.*

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- I Reopened God's house.** In his first month he opened the temple doors and restored worship. *2 Chronicles 29:3-19*

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  - 2 Invited the whole nation.** He called Judah and the remnant of the north to one Passover in Jerusalem. *2 Chronicles 30:1-12*

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  - 3 Prayed for the unready.** For those who ate unclean he prayed, "The good LORD pardon every one." *2 Chronicles 30:17-20*

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  - 4 Broke the bronze serpent.** He destroyed a holy relic from Moses' day because it had become an idol. *2 Kings 18:4*

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  - 5 Threw off Assyria's yoke.** The LORD was with him, and he rebelled against the king of Assyria and defeated the Philistines. *2 Kings 18:7-8*

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  - 6 Prepared the city.** He stopped the outside springs, rebuilt the wall, and piped water into Jerusalem. *2 Kings 20:20; 2 Chronicles 32:2-5, 30*

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  - 7 Encouraged his people.** "With him is an arm of flesh; but with us is the LORD our God to help us, and to fight our battles." *2 Chronicles 32:6-8*

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  - 8 Spread the letter before God.** He took Sennacherib's letter into the temple and prayed that all kingdoms would know the LORD. *2 Kings 19:14-19*

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  - 9 Wept and was healed.** He turned his face to the wall and prayed. God said, "I have heard thy prayer, I have seen thy tears." *2 Kings 20:2-6*

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  - 10 Showed off his treasures.** He showed Babylon's envoys everything; Isaiah warned it would all go to Babylon. *2 Kings 20:12-19; 2 Chronicles 32:25-26, 31*

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  - II Preserved wisdom.** His officials copied out a collection of Solomon's proverbs. *Proverbs 25:1*

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# Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links, not places that name Hezekiah.

## Old Testament

|                                                 |                                                     |
|-------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------|
| 2 Kings 18–20; 2 Chronicles 29–32; Isaiah 36–39 | Three accounts of his reign                         |
| Isaiah 38:9–20                                  | His psalm after recovering from illness             |
| Proverbs 25:1                                   | Proverbs "which the men of Hezekiah ... copied out" |
| Jeremiah 26:18–19                               | Elders recall that he heeded Micah's warning        |
| Hosea 1:1; Micah 1:1                            | Prophets who ministered in his reign                |
| Echo: 2 Chronicles 20:1–12                      | Jehoshaphat also prayed before a great army         |

## New Testament

|                   |                                             |
|-------------------|---------------------------------------------|
| Matthew 1:9–10    | "Ezekias" in the royal line of Jesus        |
| Echo: Hebrews 5:7 | Jesus prayed "with strong crying and tears" |

### For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Hezekiah do with Sennacherib's letter (2 Kings 19:14–19)?
2. *Understand:* Hezekiah trusted God under siege but grew proud after he was healed. Why is success sometimes harder to handle than trouble?
3. *Apply:* What "letter" or threat could you spread out before God in prayer this week?
4. *Apply:* Hezekiah broke even a relic from Moses once it became an idol. Is there something good in your life that has taken God's place?